

Are rocks discovered on Mars a sign of potential past life?

科学家在火星上发现的岩石会是生命存在过的迹象吗？

科学家在火星上发现的不同寻常的岩石中包含了这颗红色行星上可能曾有生命存在过的证据。这些岩石是由美国国家航空航天局的“毅力”号火星车在一处布满灰尘的河床上发现的，岩石上有引人注目的纹路。科学家们认为这些纹路可能含有一些矿物质，产生这些矿物质的化学反应或与远古火星微生物有关。

Nasa's Perseverance Rover has spent the past four years exploring an area of Mars called the Jezero Crater. It's dry and dusty, but billions of years ago, it was thought to be an ancient lake with a river flowing into it.

美国国家航空航天局的“毅力”号火星车在过去四年里探索了火星上被称为杰泽罗陨石坑的区域。这片区域干燥并布满灰尘，但科学家认为数十亿年前这里是一个古湖泊，有一条河流汇入其中。

The intriguing rocks were found on the riverbed. They have unusual ringed markings, **nicknamed** 'leopard spots' by the researchers, and black dots the team are calling 'poppy seeds'. These features are actually minerals, and the scientists think they could have been produced by chemical reactions associated with **microbes**.

这些引人注目的岩石就是在这里的河床上被发现的。它们带有被研究人员戏称为“豹纹”的不同寻常的环状斑纹，以及被研究团队称为“罂粟籽”的小黑点。岩石上的这些特征其实是矿物质，而科学家们认为这些矿物质可能产生自与微生物相关的化学反应。

Life isn't the only possible explanation. The minerals could have been made by natural geological processes. The only way to find out for sure is to bring the rocks back to Earth for analysis. Missions to return samples have been proposed, but there's uncertainty because of the proposed cuts to Nasa's **budget**.

生命并不是对这些矿物质的唯一解释。这些矿物质也可能产生于自然地质作用的过程。唯一能查明真相的方式就是把这些岩石带回地球进行分析。已经有人提议开展航天任务带回这些样本，但这尚存在不确定性，因为已有提议削减美国国家航空航天局的预算。

While there's still much to find out, these rocks are **tantalising**, and the findings are strong enough to meet Nasa's criteria for potential **biosignatures**, features that **warrant** further investigation to determine if they really are a sign of life.

还有许多事情尚待发掘，但这些岩石十分诱人，而且目前的研究结果所具备的说服力也达到了美国国家航空航天局对潜在生物特征的判定标准。潜在生物特征指的是“以满足值得进一步调查的理由，以确认它们是否真的是生命的迹象”。

词汇表

nicknamed	给.....起绰号
microbes	微生物
budget	预算
tantalising	诱人的
biosignatures	生物特征
warrant	使.....显得合理，使.....有必要

听力练习（答案见下页）

一、听第一遍音频，回答问题。

1. What is the main idea of this report?

二、用一分钟阅读下列问题，然后听第二遍音频并回答问题。

1. Nasa's Perseverance Rover has been exploring Mars for more than four years.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given
2. What have scientists nicknamed the unusual rock markings?
 - a. tiger eyes and lemon drops
 - b. ringed markings and black dots
 - c. leopard spots and poppy seeds
3. Life is the only possible explanation for these unusual rock markings.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given

4. What is needed to confirm whether the minerals are evidence of life?
 - a. Analysing the rocks back on Earth.
 - b. Further robotic exploration on Mars.
 - c. Sending astronauts to space.
5. Nasa has approved and fully funded the return of rock samples to Earth.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given

三、听第三遍音频，将句子补充完整。（提示：可以反复听，直到听清楚每一个词）

1. It's dry and dusty, but billions of years ago, it was _____ an ancient lake with a river flowing into it.
2. The minerals _____ made by natural geological processes.

答案

一、听第一遍音频，回答问题。

1. What is the main idea of this report?

Nasa's Perseverance Rover has found rocks in the Jezero Crater on Mars with unusual markings that may be a sign of life.

二、用一分钟阅读下列问题，然后听第二遍音频并回答问题。

1. **b. False.** The report says it has spent ***the past four years exploring***, not more.
2. **c.** *They have unusual ringed markings, **nicknamed 'leopard spots'** by the researchers, and black dots the team are calling **'poppy seeds'**.*
3. **b. False.** ***Life isn't the only possible explanation.** The minerals could have been made by **natural geological processes**.*
4. **a.** *The only way to find out for sure is to **bring the rocks back to Earth** for analysis.*
5. **b. False.** *Missions to return samples have been proposed, but **there's uncertainty because of the proposed cuts to Nasa's budget**.*

三、听第三遍音频，将句子补充完整。（提示：可以反复听，直到听清楚每一个词）

1. It's dry and dusty, but billions of years ago, it was **thought to be** an ancient lake with a river flowing into it.
2. The minerals **could have been** made by natural geological processes.